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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and other leaders attending 14th annual general assembly of Shahid Pratishthan Nepal in the capital on Saturday. The nation is currently observing the Martyrs' Week.

PM urges all Maoist factions to unite

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

Chairman of CPN (Maoist Centre) and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that unity among Maoist factions is indispensable to secure the changes achieved through people's struggle.

Addressing the 14th Annual General Meeting of Martyr Foundation Nepal (MFN) today at the Party Office of the Maoist Centre in Parisdanda in the Capital, he appealed to the leaders and workers following Maoist ideology to unite.

Indicating that it is not possible to reach the goal by being divided and mentioning that the state has moved forward in addressing the issues of martyrs, disappeared persons and injured persons of the people's war, PM Prachanda expressed his commitment that the classification of the injured at the people's war would be done.

"It is said that some individuals are still missing from being listed as injured, they will be included in the list of the injured. The state has supported the families of martyrs, missing and injured, the entire party line should realise that," he said.

Chairman Prachanda, who is also the patron of the foundation, assured that the government will take responsibility of the schools operated by the foundation. He said that the school education bill submitted in the House also covers such schools.

Stating that the foundation is united as per the intention that martyrs should not be divided, he expressed his belief that now all Maoist ideologies will be unified. "A situation is being developed where those who have made the same sacrifices will join the same centre, and the establishment should also try to bring all those who have the objective of scientific socialism together," he said. "The leadership of the new generation will be born from that unity," added PM Prachanda.

Stressing on the positive work done by the Maoist Party and its leadership to be taken to the people, he said that the economic prosperity, good governance and social justice initiated by the government has succeeded in instilling hope in the people.

According to him, the government is working to complete the remaining work of the peace process soon. He also expressed his belief that the bill related to transitional justice will be finalised through consensus, and noted that the model of Nepal's peace process is exemplary for the outside world as well.

Susta locals draw serious attention of govt to resolve their grievances

BY BOM LAL GIRI
Nawalpur, Jan. 27

Local residents of Susta area in Western Nawalparasi have vehemently drawn the attention of the government to resolve the border related issue with India saying that they had been facing oppression and harassment from Indian security forces and encroachment of land due to border dispute between the two sides.

Adam Khan, an officiating president of the Save Susta Campaign, urged the government to promptly address the border dispute in Susta.

He said, "If the government does not manage land in Susta, we will take the matter to the Supreme Court to present our case of grievances and difficulties."

Kisan Sharma Gaire, an advisor to the Save Susta Campaign, said that they had consulted with the concerned stakeholders and taking advice regarding a petition about this issue.

The locals who had been fighting for their land were in preparation to file a case to make their voices heard by the government.

On one hand, the land dispute in the border area has been dragging for an extended period of time and on the other, many Susta locals fighting for their ancestral land have not been able to obtain their citizenships.

Currently, Susta has a population of 3,133 living in 265 households. However, based on the voters' list, only 295 individuals in Susta have obtained Nepali citizenship.

Prabhunath Yadav, chair of Ward No. 5 in Susta, said that the government should provide citizenship to the Susta residents through different packages. He said that around 1,600 people in Susta eligible for citizenship had not obtained citizenship.



PHOTO: BOM LAL GIRI/TRN

Nepali and Indian security personnels conducting a joint patrol on the border between Nepal's Susta and India.

TRN SPECIAL

"You can't get even a SIM card if you don't have a citizenship certificate. What else can you do?" questioned Rabindra Jaiswal, a local resident.

"Many youths here are not able to work either in Nepal or in India in absence of citizenship papers. They can't open bank accounts. They can't apply for driving license. Who will understand the suffering of Susta populace?, he asked.

Along with citizenship, most of the residents in Susta are not able to receive land ownership certificates either. Susta spans over 40,980 hectares of land. Of this, Indian side is reported to have encroached 14,500 hectares.

Anil Thapa, inspector of Armed Police Force, Nepal border outpost (BOP) in Susta, said that 19,980 hectares of land had been marked as disputed area. Nepal has only been able to utilise 7,000 hectares and among them, only 556 bighas of land are registered in the name of the locals, he added.

Previously, there was a Village Panchayat consisting of nine wards. However, the Panchayat was displaced after the floods in the Narayani River in 1977. Later, India started encroaching from the southern side of the displaced area. Advisor Gaire said that the displaced Nepalis in that area should be repatriated and get their land ownership certificates.

Gaire, who is also the central member of the CPN (Maoist Centre), said that they had formed a Joint Struggle Committee of people living on both sides of the Narayani River to make the Prime Minister aware of the issue. The committee was working to allow Susta residents to live with pride and educate their children, he added.

The residents of Ward No. 5 in Susta Municipality have been actively engaged in the struggle against the border encroachment for a long time. However, their grievances have not been heard and addressed when it comes to exercising their rights within their own country.

Additionally, the locals have endured a lack of education, healthcare and electricity.

Meanwhile, a suspension bridge constructed over the Narayani River to facilitate Susta locals is still under construction. Approximately 90 per cent of the construction work of the bridge with a length of 1.4 kilometres has been completed.

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Chinese assistance significant for country's prosperity: DPM Shrestha

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 27



DPM Narayan Kaji Shrestha

Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha has said Chinese assistance was significant for Nepal's economic prosperity. Nepal-China cooperation is a pillar of infrastructure building in Nepal, Shrestha added.

DPM Shrestha said it during a 'Silk Road Youth Forum' organized by Silk Road International Think Tank Exchange Centre, the Sino-Nepal Media Society, and the World Sinology Centre, Beijing Language and Culture University in Kathmandu on Saturday.

Construction of roads, bridges and energy projects has not only enhanced Nepal-China connectivity but also fostered regional cooperation and unity, DPM Shrestha said, adding that cultural exchanges are also important mediums to foster bilateral ties.

"Common cultural heritages and age-old traditions are solid foundation to forge understanding," he reminded.

According to the DPM, socioeconomic relations between Nepal and China for common development are exemplary; it has been beneficial in forwarding initiatives on sustainable development and inclusive growth.

He further observed that China-forwarded 'Belt and Road Initiatives' has become a pivotal mechanism to shape south Asia's economic landscape. BRI has emphasized connectivity, infrastructure development, economic cooperation and exploration of new potential in this region, Shrestha reminded.

According to the DPM, the Nepal-China relations are based on ancient and traditional respect, understanding and cooperation in each other. "China is firm on its assistance to its socio-economic development in Nepal," he mentioned.

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'Nepal-India relations advancing in unique way'

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

Foreign Minister Narayan Prakash Saud has said that Nepal-India relations have advanced smoothly in a unique way.

Addressing a programme organised in the capital on Saturday on the 75th Republic Day of India, Minister Saud said that the deep relations existing between the peoples of the two countries would be strengthened further by resolving the issues raised in different stages on the basis of dialogue and discussions. "As the issues of Treaty of Peace and Friendship of 1950 and border are multidimensional topics between the two countries, a decision should be made by being objective and practical," the Foreign Minister said.

As both the countries are close friends, Minister Saud said that differences on the common agendas even cannot be imagined and added that the security personnel deployed on the border security need training and instructions to give good treatment and good conducts on the peoples in the bordering region.

During the meetings with Indian leaders and citizens alike, the minister said that the Indians are cordial towards Nepal and Nepalis and added that he has realized the Indian side's mentality to resolve the border issues in Susta and Kalapani through a taskforce in a cordial manner.

On the occasion, former Vice President Paramananda Jha stressed the need for working together to further deepen Nepal-India relations at the grassroots level too.

Likewise, Maoist Centre's leader Devendra Poudel argued that Nepal and India should work together to combat the common challenges of the humanity.

CPN (UML) leader Dr Rajan Bhattarai said that Nepal-India relations should be defined in line with the peoples' existing level of understanding and perceptions.

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People's Front leader sets example in fruit cultivation

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Jan. 27

Rajendra Prasad Gaire of Walling Municipality-10 is equally active in agriculture and politics. One can feel that he is still young while observing his active life in politics and agriculture even though he has completed seven decades of his life. He reaches his farm early in the morning and spends the whole day with the plants of oranges, bananas, and other seasonal fruits.

Gaire is the President for Syangja district of the National People's Front. Since he should also be active in politics, he has employed two workers in the agricultural farm. He has experienced that no matter how many people you have, if you don't do it by yourself, you can't produce as much as you think.

Gaire, who started fruit farming after buying 60 ropanis of fallow land, earned Rs. 1 million by selling oranges this year. The sweet lime and banana crops in his garden are starting to yield income, and he is hopeful of increased income in the years to come. He has been involved in fruit farming for over two decades now.



He has been giving equal importance to politics and agricultural works for the past 10 years. He argues that there will be a problem if he does not manage or earn the money that he needs to spend by himself.

There is an understanding that Nepal's leaders do not pay attention to earning and only do politics which has contributed to increased corruption, he said. He said that he started fruit farming since 2056-57 BS. He has registered his agricultural farm and does the business formally.

Gaire had entered into politics by supporting the CPN (Marxist-Leninist) while he was a student in Tansen, Palpa. He joined All Nepal Peasants Association in 1991 and elected the district secretary of the NPF known as Rastriya Janamorcha Nepal in 1993. Later in 1999, he was elected as the district president of the NPF and has been serving in the same capacity since then.

He has sent an example for the youth that they can involve themselves in agriculture or any business in the country and earn a good amount of money while staying with their family.

"We should not just do politics, we should be able to earn our own expenses," he said. He has planted orange plants in his land and created a forest of fruits. Of the 1,800 plants he has planted in the forest, 300 have started growing fruits and yielding income.

Everywhere you look, there is only unwanted forest and if you can manage it and plant income-generating plants such as oranges, the standard of living will also rise, he noted.

He said that the government should provide subsidies and other facilities to the real farmers.

Economic prosperity is need of nation: FM Dr. Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that Nepal's unique products, services and goods have not been adequately marketed. Inaugurating the NMA Marketing Summit-2024 organised by the Nepal Marketing Association, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that it was incumbent upon all of us for marketing Nepali products together.

"Uniqueness is now a trend around the world. Many countries are far ahead of us in terms of uniqueness. Marketing can be done all over the world by producing unique products in Nepal. Consumers always prefer to be different from others. Nepal's advantage is its uniqueness," Minister Dr. Mahat said, "Our traditions, culture, religion, wildlife and unity constitute unique identity of our country."

"We have to advertise the products. But, advertising alone is not enough, there must be qualities to make them sustainable. If there is no quality, they will not appeal," he said. Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the country's economy, which was problematic, is gradually improving.



PHOTO: TRN
Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat speaking in the NMA Marketing Summit-2024 in Kathmandu on Saturday.

He said, "Our economic indicators are positive. Inflation is under control and interest rates are decreasing. The stock market is improving. And, economic activities are also gradually becoming vibrant." Stating that political infrastructure has been prepared through many political ups and downs, he said that now we need to build economic infrastructure.

He said that there was a need to boost the confidence among the people and investors to accelerate the economic activities. "For that, a positive message should be conveyed. So far we have talked about a lot of negative things, because of this we have weakened our confidence," Minister Dr. Mahat said. "Confidence in our business will increase with positive messaging."

Stating that economic prosperity and infrastructure development must be in top priority, he said the national economy is gradually getting back on track.

"So, infrastructure development should be intensified," he added.

The Finance Minister said that the economy was improving gradually amidst political upheaval.

Pashupatinagar Customs collects Rs. 13.41M revenue

RSS
Ilam, Jan. 27

Pashupatinagar Customs Office in Ilam has collected Rs 13.41 million revenue in the first six months of the current fiscal year 2080/81 BS. It was 69.96 per cent of the target.

The Office has set a target of collecting Rs 19.17 million revenue in the current fiscal year. Similarly, the office had collected Rs 10.2 million revenue in the fiscal year 2077/78 BS against the target of collecting Rs 28.99 million, said Office Chief, Prabin Subba.

Likewise, it had collected Rs 8.73 million revenue against its target of collecting Rs 25.34 million revenue in the fiscal year 2078/79 BS. Subba added that the Customs Office had collected Rs 27.18 million revenue in the fiscal year 2079/80 BS. It had set a target of collecting Rs 25.085 million revenue during the period. The highest revenue was collected from auction of illegally brought goods.

Lahan Expo from April 11

RSS
Siraha, Jan. 27

Lahan Expo: Madhes Province International Festival is going to be held in coming April at Lahan of Siraha district. Siraha Chamber of Commerce and Industry is organising the expo to be held at the premises of Lahan-based Pashupati Adarsha Secondary School with an objective of establishing friendly relation between the producers and consumers.

President of Siraha Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Bikas Sarada, informed that the expo would be held from April 11-21. He said they believed that the Lahan expo will contribute significantly in the plan of promoting country's economic activities as well as will be an important step to build friendly relation in industry, trade and cultural sectors.

Total 150 stalls would be kept in display in the expo organised with an objective of bringring investors, producers, distributors and exporters of Nepal, Pakistan and Bangladesh together and informed them about the goods.

Dhakal urges NRNs in Qatar to invest back home

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI), has urged the Nepali immigrants in Qatar to invest in various sectors of Nepal.

Addressing the conference of 'Nepal Business Association Qatar' held in Doha, Dhakal called for investment in Nepal's tourism, infrastructure development, renewable energy and agriculture sectors.

"Nepal has a lot of potential for investment in areas like tourism, infrastructure development, renewable energy and agriculture. Likewise, Qatar's development experience in the fields of renewable energy, tourism and hospitality, infrastructure development, urbanisation, and information technology can be used in Nepal," he said according to a statement issued by his secretariat.

According to Dhakal, Nepali workers have contributed to the economic growth and development of Qatar so Nepalis in Qatar should establish a technical school in Nepal to create skilled workers.

He argued that the provision of citizenship made by the Nepali government for non-resident Nepalis should also encourage the Nepalis scattered around the world to invest in Nepal.

As the Government of Nepal is going to hold an investment conference in collaboration with the FNCCI to attract foreign investment in Nepal, he urged them to promote the investment environment and opportunities in Nepal and encourage Qatari investors to come to Nepal.



FILE PHOTO
Chandra Dhakal

Dhakal said that the government has expressed its commitment to create an investment-friendly environment by removing many legal obstacles. "Within a few years, Nepal will be upgraded from a Least Developed Country (LDC) to a developing country. It will create many possibilities in Nepal's economy and Qatar can become a major partner in our drive to diversify the economy," he said.

He also said that the recent high-level agreement on energy with India is positive and it has paved the way for investment in hydropower and energy trade in our country.

Cereals import drops by 20 per cent

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

The import of cereals to the country has decreased significantly during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

According to a latest trade statistics of the Department of Customs, food imports have decreased by 20 per cent in terms of monetary value during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24 as compared to the same period last fiscal year 2022/23.

Similarly, in terms of quantity, the import of cereals has decreased by 25 per cent during the review period as compared to the corresponding period last year.

During the review period, about 478,202 tonnes of cereals worth Rs. 22.22 billion have been imported. The country imported about 644,584 tonnes of cereals worth Rs. 27.91 billion in the first six months of the last fiscal year. The import of cereals has decreased due to decrease in the import of paddy and rice.

The paddy import has dropped by 47 per cent and rice by 43 per cent during the review period as compared to the same period last year. About 138,304 tonnes of paddy worth Rs. 5.14 billion and 49,404 tonnes of rice worth Rs. 5 billion have been imported during the first six months of the current fiscal year.

In the first six months of the last fiscal year, about 279,170 tonnes of paddy worth Rs. 9.73 billion and 144,371 tonnes of rice worth Rs. 8.89 billion had been imported in the first six months of the last year.



> The country imported about 644,584 tonnes of cereals worth Rs. 27.91 billion in the first six months of the last fiscal year. The import of cereals has decreased due to decrease in the import of paddy and rice.

Due to the increase in paddy production this year, the import of rice and paddy may have decreased during the review period. The Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development has estimated that around 5.724 million tonnes have been produced this year.

However, the import of wheat has also increased significantly during the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year. The country imported 123,666 tonnes of wheat worth Rs. 4.98 billion during the review period. The import of wheat increased by 70 times during the review period as compared to the same period last fiscal year.

Only 1,895 tonnes of wheat worth Rs. 66 million had been imported during the first six months of the last fiscal year. Last year, Nepali industries were in trouble as India imposed restrictions on wheat exports and increased customs duties. In the last fiscal year 2022/23, wheat worth Rs. 280 million had been imported.

In the meantime, the import of maize has decreased by 25 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last year. The country has imported 157,402 tonnes of maize worth Rs. 6.63 billion during the review period. About 208,251 tonnes of maize worth Rs. 8.81 billion had been imported in the same period last fiscal year.

Likewise, 197 tonnes of buckwheat worth Rs. 14.4 million, 8,906 tonnes of millet worth Rs. 437 million and 296 tonnes of barley worth Rs. 11 million have been imported during the review period.

SME village being built at Bardaghat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

A Model Industrial Village (SME Village) is being built at Bardaghat Municipality in Nawalparasi (West). The foundation stone of the industrial village was laid on Friday after completing the preparatory works including budget management and project construction contracts.

Industry, Commerce and Supply Minister, Ramesh Rijal and Member of Parliament from the area, Binod Chaudhary, jointly laid the foundation stone of the project.

With the resource allocation for the industrial village in the budget of the current Fiscal Year 2023/24, preparations for the project have progressed. Integrated facilities will be available in this village that aims to utilise the creative entrepreneurship of the local youth and skills based on local raw materials.

This village is being built in Bardghat Municipality Ward No. 5, Khajura Khola area in about 18 bigaha land.

It is estimated that Rs. 170 million will be needed to develop this project which is aimed to be completed within the next three years.

For this year, Rs. 40 million have been released for this project and the contract to develop it has already been awarded. If required, an additional budget would be disbursed for its construction, said Chaudhary.

Engineers from Chaudhary Foundation will directly support the project without any financial burden to carry forward this project effectively.



Speaking on the occasion, Minister Rijal expressed his belief that the model industrial village will contribute significantly to the industrialisation and economic development of the region. He also said that the government is ready to cooperate with the private sector and will take initiatives to improve policies for industrial development.

"We are promoting youth entrepreneurship training for young people. And we will also take the necessary steps to arrange seed capital for them," Chaudhary said. He also informed that he and his team will continuously support and monitor the construction of the project.

The Special Economic Zone Authority under the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies has been facilitating the construction of the model industrial village.

Mayor of Bardaghat Municipality, Shambhu Lal Shrestha said that it is very good news that a model industrial village is being constructed in the municipality.

Avian flu devastates farms in California

AP
Petaluma, Calif., Jan. 27

Last month, Mike Weber got the news every poultry farmer fears: His chickens tested positive for avian flu. Following government rules, Weber's company, Sunrise Farms, had to slaughter its entire flock of egg-laying hens — 550,000 birds — to prevent the disease from infecting other farms in Sonoma County north of San Francisco.

"It's a trauma. We're all going through grief as a result of it," said Weber, standing in an empty hen house. "Petaluma is known as the Egg Basket of the World. It's devastating to see that egg basket go up in flames."

A year after the bird flu led to record egg prices and widespread shortages, the disease known as highly pathogenic avian influenza is wreaking havoc in California, which escaped the earlier wave of outbreaks that devastated poultry farms in the Midwest.

The highly contagious virus has ravaged Sonoma County, where officials have declared a state of emergency. During the past two months, nearly a dozen commercial farms have had to destroy more than 1 million birds to control the outbreak, dealing an economic blow to farmers, workers and their customers.

Merced County in Central California also has been hit hard, with outbreaks at several large commercial egg-producing farms in recent weeks.

Experts say bird flu is spread by ducks, geese and other migratory birds. The waterfowl can carry the virus without getting sick and easily spread it through their droppings to chicken and turkey farms and backyard flocks through droppings and nasal discharges.

California poultry farms are implementing strict biosecurity measures to curb the spread of the disease. State Veterinarian Annette Jones urged farmers to keep their flocks indoors until June, including organic chickens that are required to have outdoor access. "We still have migration going for another couple of months.

So we've got to be as vigilant as possible to protect our birds," said Bill Mattos, president of the California Poultry Federation.

The loss of local hens led to a spike in egg prices in the San Francisco Bay Area over the holidays before supermarkets and restaurants found suppliers from outside the region. While bird flu has been around for decades, the current outbreak of the virus that began in early 2022 has prompted officials to slaughter nearly 82 million birds, mostly egg-laying chickens, in 47 U.S. states, according to the U.S. Department of Agriculture. Whenever the disease is found the entire flock is slaughtered to help limit the spread of the virus.

The price of a dozen eggs more than doubled to $4.82 at its peak in January 2023. Egg prices returned to their normal range as egg producers built up their flocks and outbreaks were controlled.

Turkey and chicken prices also spiked, partly due to the virus.

"I think this is an existential issue for the commercial poultry industry. The virus is on every continent, except for Australia at this point," said Maurice Pitesky, a poultry expert at the University of California, Davis.

Climate change is increasing the risk of outbreaks as changing weather patterns disrupt the migratory patterns of wild birds, Pitesky said. For example, exceptional rainfall last year created new waterfowl habitat throughout California, including areas close to poultry farms.

In California, the outbreak has impacted more than 7 million chickens in about 40 commercial flocks and 24 backyard flocks, with most of the outbreaks occurring over the past two months on the North Coast and Central Valley, according to the USDA.

Industry officials are worried about the growing number of backyard chickens that could become infected and spread avian flu to commercial farms. "We have wild birds that are are full of virus. And if you expose your birds to these wild birds, they might get infected and ill," said Rodrigo Gallardo, a UC Davis researcher who studies avian influenza.

Gallardo advises the owners of backyard chickens to wear clean clothes and shoes to protect their flocks from getting infected. If an unusual number of chickens die, they should be tested for avian flu.

Call for an autonomous mechanism to ensure quality of Diploma engineers

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

Operators of Diploma in Engineering education have voiced their demand for an autonomous mechanism to register diploma engineers following a quality test before entering the workforce.

This call was made during an interaction programme organized by the Education Journalist Network (EJON) on Friday, where participants emphasized the necessity of standardizing the three-year diploma study.

Currently, there are a total of 1571 educational institutions across the country offering Diploma in Engineering without any quality accreditation, raising concerns among stakeholders.

During the interaction, Sunil Chalise, the vice-chair of the Forum for Health and Technical Education, underscored the importance of the government's commitment to developing a mechanism for conducting quality tests of human resources in this field.

The existing practice of the Nepal Engineering Council involves granting licenses exclusively to Bachelor of Engineering graduates after they pass a standardized test. Stakeholders are urging for a similar mechanism to be established for quality control within their domain.

This move aims to ensure that diploma engineers meet certain standards and competencies before entering the workforce, contributing to the overall enhancement of the quality of engineering education in the country.



PHOTO: TRN

Ministry of Education, Science and Technology spokesperson Shiva Sapkota and other authorities at an interaction programme on Quality Assurance of Diploma Engineering of Nepal.

Former member secretary of the Council for Technical Education and Vocational Training Dr. Ramhari Lamichhane said, "If it can be arranged to conduct professional exams through the Nepal Engineering Council or other such bodies that only regulate diploma engineering, quality can be maintained in this field."

Meanwhile, the Ministry of Physical Planning and Infrastructure said the government has been preparing to register diploma engineering also with the Council.

Sushant Subedi, an engineer of the ministry, said that the work for the license has been going on for a long time.

"In the past, when a proposal was sent to the Ministry of Finance to form a separate body to grant licenses to diploma-level engineering subjects, it was suggested that this should be done by the current Engineering Council," said Subedi, "but we have given the opinion that a separate council should be formed, and we have started the process as well"

> The existing practice of the Nepal Engineering Council involves granting licenses exclusively to Bachelor of Engineering graduates after they pass a standardized test.

Registrar of Nepal Engineering Council Shivamangal Giri said that the government should permit the license examination for diploma-level engineering as well, and the existing law of the council should be revised. The present Act of the Council has given the authority to grant licenses only to Bachelor of Engineering graduates."

However, Shiva Sapkota, joint secretary of the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, said that the students who have passed the university and board exams should not be put in trouble again.

Mahesh Bhattarai, member secretary of CTEVT, said that the question of quality has arisen not only in the technical field but also in the overall education system of the country. Therefore, authorities must be serious about this.

YOUTHS OF BANKE DUPED BY MANPOWER AGENCIES

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Banke, Jan. 27

Amar Bahadur Budhamgar from Khajura Rural Municipality Ward No. 4 in Banke, finds himself in a distressing situation after he paid Rs. 230,000 to a manpower company two years ago. Budhamagar has been paying a 36 per cent interest rate for the money he borrowed to go to Dubai as a migrant worker.

The manpower company deceived him, and Budhamagar finds it almost impossible to pay the borrowed sum with the accumulated interest.

Speaking at a press conference in Nepalgunj, Budhamgar revealed, "Two days after making the payment, the former agent of the manpower company, Homanath Yogi from Surkhet is out of contact. The interest is escalating day by day and I have lost the capital as well."

Nine individuals, including Gopal Bahadur Thapa Magar, and Prem Sunar had paid 1.5 lakhs to Yogi. Gopal Bahadur Thapa, one of the victims, recounted that Yogi, after convincing 12 individuals, including nine from Egaon, called them to Kathmandu, claiming that visas and tickets had arrived. Thapa mentioned that he paid Rs.250,000 after he was assured of the arrival of his visa, but he was conned.

The victims revealed that Yogi provided them with fake tickets and, after spending a month in Kathmandu, they returned to their village empty-handed and the manpower agent disappeared. Frustrated and unable to fulfill their aspirations, some victims resorted to seeking employment in various cities of India to pay the accruing interest.

Through a press conference, the victims have now appealed to the government to locate Homanath Yogi, and help them get back their money.

Renovation of Birendra Nagar clock tower in final stage



PHOTO: TRN

The clock tower in Birendra Nagar, Surkhet is in the final stage of renovation.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Jan. 27

The renovation of the clock tower, a prominent tourist attraction in Birendra Nagar, Surkhet, has entered its final phase. Following the deterioration and partial collapse of the existing wall constructed years ago, the municipality initiated the construction of a new wall through a contract. Birendranagar Municipality has announced the completion of the first phase of wall construction, which commenced in May last year. Currently, the clock tower's wall has been successfully erected, and the finishing touches, including painting, are underway.

Namaste Construction Services undertook the responsibility for the wall construction, and the company is currently focused on installing the iron railing after completing the wall structure. As per the construction company's timeline, the installation of lights will be completed within a week, marking the project's conclusion.

The newly constructed walls showcases artistic elements, incorporating stones from Rolpa. The municipality highlights its versatility, indicating that it can serve as a canvas for showcasing Surkhet's cultural heritage, with plans to adorn it with flowering plants akin to the Surkhet Chinari wall.

Ishwari Dhakal, the engineer of a local government, emphasized the enhanced visibility of the clock tower during night-time due to strategically placed lights on the wall. The initial phase of the Ghantaghar Park wall construction incurred a cost of 46 lakhs. Meanwhile, a contract has been awarded for the second phase, covering the remaining wall sections and the primary entrance gate of Ghantaghar Park, with Jagannath Construction overseeing the project at an estimated cost of around 5.5 million. The contractual agreement is expected to be in effect until the completion of the second phase in May. Notably, the clock housed within the tower, having served for almost 12 years and with an expenditure of 11.5 lakh rupees, has also been replaced.

LITERARY PROGRAMME TO FIND TALENT'

RSS
Khajura, Jan 27

Khajura rural municipality of Banke district has launched a massive literary programme to explore talent. The Khajura academy organised a literary event in a bid to find talent persons. Vice Chancellor of the academy, Dr Indra Bahadur Bhandari, informed that the three-day programme kicked off today. Talent in various eight genres as singing, dance, painting, essay, poetry, proverb, speech would be identified from competitive programmes.

Competitive programmes are held on Saturday and Sunday and the excellent ones in respective category will be awarded on Tuesday, Dr Bhandari added. Earlier, such programme was organized in limited genres. The programme in present form is first of its kind, according to him. It will be focused on 'Ma and Mero Khajura' (I and My Khajura).

Academy member Madhav Sharma shared that it is a huge programme involving many students from Khajura rural municipality. It helps foster student's creativity and talent, he believed, adding that there is potential of literature and art here. Such programme is organized every year, the academy informed.

Palanquin culture vanishes in Bajura after villages linked with road network



PHOTO: TRN

A groom of Bajura in his marriage ceremony with other locals.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bajura, Jan. 27

In recent times, the traditional palanquin (doli) has been vanishing from many weddings in Bajura.

Bharuni Nepali, a resident of Khaptad Chededah Rural Municipality, said, "The iconic doli that was used to carry the brides have almost vanished as almost every village is linked with the road network."

"Earlier during the wedding the bride's family would prepare a doli to carry the bride to her new home, but slowly the tradition of carrying the bride in a doli has died away.

The persons carrying the palanquin lost their traditional jobs after the traditional palanquins were replaced by cars.

With the advent of roads in the village, he mentioned that they opted for a more modern approach when his son got married, bringing the daughter-in-law in a car. The beautiful tradition of carrying the bride in a palanquin too faded away.

Before 2009, many villages in Bajura used doli and horses in wedding ceremonies. However, post-2019, as villages gained road access, most villages and hamlets in Jagannath, Swamikartik, Budhinanda, Gaumul Badimalika, Budhiganga Triveni, and Khaptad Chededah Rural Municipality in Bajura have become accessible through road networks.

This widespread accessibility to road networks has led to the diminishing presence of dolis in Bajura, as modern conveniences, particularly cars, are becoming increasingly favoured during weddings, despite the cherished tradition of the doli being considered the best.

KU, Australian institute agree for double degree programme in BIT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

The School of Engineering at Kathmandu University of Nepal and the Crown Institute of Higher Education (CIHE) of Australia have signed a Letter of Agreement (LoA) on 26 January to launch a double degree programme in Bachelor of Information Technology.

The agreement provides the guidelines for the initiation and administration of the double degree programme in Bachelor of Information Technology (BIT) as conceived by the Definitive Agreement signed between the two institutions on August 1, 2023.

The LoA outlines the fee structures and scholarships for student intake in 2024, informed Dr. Bal Krishna Bal, Programme Coordinator of Bachelor of Information Technology at the KU.

"The MoU aimed at establishing the way for a multifaceted partnership aimed at enhancing international cooperation in academia encompassing various collaborative initiatives, including Staff Exchanges, Student Exchange Programmes, and the Exchange of Academic Materials between the two esteemed institutions," said Dr. Bal.

Furthermore, the MoU also envisioned joint efforts to establish and implement innovative joint degree courses, demonstrating a commitment to shared academic pursuits.

The Definitive Agreement (DA) was also signed on the same day, outlining the commencement of a Double Degree Programme in Bachelor of Information Technology (BIT).

This unique academic collaboration allows for a maximum intake of 30 students per cycle, offering them a remarkable opportunity to immerse themselves in the rich academic environments of both KU and Australia within the dynamic field of information technology.

For the programme, the CIHE will be providing a discounted fee arrangement setting the tuition fee at AUS$ 7200 per semester, in contrast to the regular AUS$ 9000 per semester. KU, on the other hand, will be adopting the same fee structure for its Bachelor in Computer Science programme for the first two years study period.

The KU offers a comprehensive scholarship scheme, awarding100 per cent scholarship to the highest achiever, 50 per cent to the second highest, and 25 per cent to the third-highest performer in each semester, applicable to the tuition fees for the subsequent semester at KU. Similarly, the Crown Institute of Higher Education (CIHE) extends additional scholarship opportunities, providing a 15 per cent scholarship to students maintaining a High Distinction average and 10 per cent to those achieving a Distinction average while studying at CIHE.

Additionally, CIHE also grants 50 per cent tuition fee waiver to the student topping the batch during their studies at KU with the highest CGPA for three semesters.

If students choose to continue their studies in Nepal or face challenges securing an Australian visa, they have the flexibility to transition seamlessly to either the Bachelor of Computer Science or the Bachelor of Technology in Artificial Intelligence programmes at Kathmandu University. If 50 per cent or more of the students face such circumstances, the Department will provide a full-fledged BIT programme for the remaining two years, ensuring continuity in their academic journey and the possibility of graduating as a BIT graduate from Kathmandu University itself.

Registrar of the KU, Prof. Dr. Achyut Wagle, said that the collaboration was about creating alliance with foreign educational institutions. "Governments of both countries are positive about this collaboration. Australian ambassador to Nepal was present during the agreement signing programme," he said.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Engineering Service Directorate
Concrete Pole Plant Project Lamki
Lamki, Kailali

INVITATION FOR BIDS
(Online Bids Only)

Date of Notice Publication : 2080/10/14 (28th January, 2024)

S.N.	Description of Procurement	Tender No.	For Detailed Information
1.	Supply and Delivery of 53 Grade OPC Cement as Per Technical Specification at Plant Site, Lamki, Kailali.	NEA-CPPL-2080/81-ST-04	Please visit official website of PPMO **(www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp)** and NEA, Concrete Pole Plant Lamki., Lamki, Kailali, Phone No.: 091-590038

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Weakness of attitude becomes weakness of character.
- Albert Einstein

EDITORIAL

Renewable Energy Bill

The era of renewable energy is upon us. The rapid pace at which it is being adopted across the world has even astounded experts closely observing the trend. And Nepal is not an exception. From a fleet of school buses and public microbuses to bikes and scooters, electric vehicles (EV) have started being seen on every road in growing number. This powerful momentum towards clean energy only seems unstoppable. Not just vehicles, everything from cooking to heating, we are now employing renewable energy in the form of hydroelectricity – a mirror of the big shift in the way how the world produces energy and uses it in a clean and green way as per the call of the time.

In the age of climate change, transition to 100 per cent renewable energy is not only a moral obligation to future generations, but is also socially and economically beneficial today. Across the world, the developed nations that burned fossil fuels for more than a century to become the richest economies on the planet are rapidly shifting away from such fuels. Automakers have made electric vehicles central to their business strategies and are keenly talking about an expiration date on the internal combustion engine. As the planet witnesses record-shattering temperatures, governments around the world are pouring trillions of dollars into clean energy to cut the carbon pollution that is causing the warming. The cost of generating electricity from the sun and wind is falling so fast that it is now competitive with their fossil fuel counterparts in price.

The incumbent government is going to present the 'Renewable Energy and Energy Efficiency Bill' with the objective to address the changing circumstances and demands of the times in the field of alternative and renewable energies. Minister of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet has assured that the bill related to renewable energy will be tabled in the federal parliament within a month. We welcome the announcement, and urge the government to expedite it. Not only will it help regulate and manage the massive number of EVs, it will also turbocharge our efforts towards producing cleaner and more sustainable energy.

Studies have shown that Nepal is one of the best-placed countries to harness the power of the sun. With plenty of sunny days and cooler climate, the solar power the country can tap into is immense, and so is the wind power with no shortage of windy areas like Mustang, Manang and Kathmandu among many others. The bill should contain measures and provisions to incentivise the power producers to maximise this untapped potential. A law in place to protect and power energy producers will surely give those in the field a confidence to carry on with their businesses without fear.

As country after country strives to increase its share of renewable energy, we cannot afford to lag behind. They are giving generous subsidies, tax breaks and even capital support to hasten the shift. Several laws have been enacted in this regard. We producing enough clean energy will both lower the cost of electricity and curb the import of fossil fuel – the import of which is a drain on our foreign currency reserves. Once it is signed into law, the bill is sure to be instrumental in prompting new power producers to foray into the venture and be a key part of the timely shift.

Ram's Ideals Go Beyond India

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

After settling down decades-old legal squabble and maintaining harmony in the society, the Indian government and Hindu community constructed Maru-Gurjara style huge Ram Temple having five segments in Ajodhya. The temple covers an area of seven plus acres of land. The initial estimated cost for the construction of the Temple is said to be USD 217 million. After the management committee installed a 1.3 metre tall statue of Lord Ram at the inner sanctum of the temple decked in intricate gold ornaments on January 21, Prime Minister Narendra Modi reached Ayodhaya in Utter Pradesh and inaugurated the Temple in presence of about 7,500 dignitaries.

The invitees included politicians, industrialists, renowned social figures, movie stars, saints, gurus and pundits of different sects and common people. Amid chanting of Vedic hymns and worships, Premier Modi offered Pooja and opened the temple for public. Ram is a human incarnation of God of the Hindu pantheons of gods who was born at the exact site in Ayodhya in the prehistoric times called Treta Yuga.

India has been proving itself as one of the leading nations in economy, technology and stable democratic set-up. In the recent years, India has been building mega infrastructures such as railways, highways and airports. Along with the construction of Ram Temple in Ayodhaya, the single lane roads of the age old city have been widened into four lanes, hotels of international standards and a big airport have also been built. Those all constructions will have far-reaching impacts on economy and tourism industry.

The grandeur of the Maru-Gujara architecture of the temple, hundreds of years struggle and sacrifice by the people and jubilant mood and pride of the majority of the Indian people reminds me of a grand temple opening ceremony in Japan. Some thirteen years ago, Todai-ji Buddha temple was inaugurated at Nara in Japan.

As Japanese Emperor Shomu Tenna (724-749 CE) ordered an architect monk named Roben to build a Buddha temple at Nara, Roben collected donations from 2.6 million people across the country and began constructing 84-pillar huge Temple. He also built 16-metre tall bronze statue of Lord Buddha. On the opening ceremony, in the year 752 CE, Emperor Tenna invited royals of all Korea China and officials and dignitaries from across the 'known world'. The Great Temple was opened in presence of the royals and over ten thousand monks. It is said that over four thousand dancers performed on the auspicious opening ceremony.

Bearing these two great civilisations in mind, this scribe has some reservations about the consecration of Ram's statue in Ayodhaya. First, Lord Ram's values, ideals and morals go beyond India. Nepal, Thailand, Indonesia, Myanmar and Malaysia are some of the nations which revere Lord Ram. Therefore, whether the Indian government invited guests from those countries or not. Secondly, if the representatives of all the religions had participated in the programme including opposition political parties, it would have been in accordance with the teachings of Lord Ram.

Thirdly, even the ruling party leaders in their speeches claim that they would lead the nation to Treta Yuga. This sounds awkward. Pre-historic social accounts in the secret scriptures clearly say that neither the Treta Yuga nor the Dwapar was as fantastic as this Kali Yuga that we live in.

Reviewing Vladimir Lenin's Legacy

Ritu Raj Subedi



One hundred years after his demise, Vladimir Lenin, who masterminded the 1917 Russian Revolution, continues to inspire communist and left movements in different parts of world though the Soviet Union he created collapsed in 1990. Jan 21, 2024 marked his death centenary and the occasion was not observed with much fanfare in his own country. On Sunday, a few dozens of communist leaders and cadres attended at Red Square in Moscow and paid their respects to the man who established world's first socialist state - Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). Gennady Zyuganov, General Secretary of the Communist Party of the Russian Federation, who led the people paying tributes to the late Bolshevik leader, said, "Lenin tried to build a just world with brotherhood among nations — without capitalism."

Of course, he developed an alternative model to the capitalist system based on the theory of Marxism but it buckled under its own 'inherent contradictions,' the terms that Marx used as factors leading to the ultimate downfall of capitalism. Nonetheless, by 1922 Lenin had perceived the systemic flaws in his Soviet system - excessive bureaucratisation of party and concentration of immense powers in the hands of a single person, with the appointment of Stalin as the party general secretary. These had begun to choke the new communist dispensation from top to bottom. More importantly, there were no credible institutions and structures beyond the party, which could serve as the bulwark against the potential crisis. These institutions would also be crucial in channeling the voices, aspirations and needs of the general public.

Frustration

Lenin vehemently opposed one-man rule and personality cult. He had propounded theory of 'democratic centralism' as a guideline to elect the party leadership and run the organisation. He gradually realised that inner-party democracy was becoming weak and centralism gaining upper hand. He called for picking the leadership through the votes of Soviets of Workers' and Peasants' Deputies but he was frustrated as their powers were drained and flowed to the centre. He was afraid whether the party would not realise his vision of socialism that he had depicted in his seminal work *'State and Revolution.'*

In order to reverse these trends, Lenin asked his comrades to remove Stalin from general secretary, citing that he was ill-suited for the position and install Leon Trotsky in his place. In *'Lenin Testament,'* he appreciated Trotsky's superior intellect but at the same time disapproved his penchant towards excess administration. He prescribed that the man who holds this position 'should be more tolerant, more polite and more attentive towards comrades, less capricious, etc.' Physically frail and bed-ridden, Lenin's plea for the leadership change was lost in the wilderness.

As a pioneer in developing and implementing Marxism, Lenin's legacy has been contested. His methods of dealing with the opposition and enemies were harsh and sometime ruthless, especially when his nascent communist state faced an existential threat. This approach has largely been blamed for the rise of Stalin, who did not only accumulate all powers in his hands but also brutally sidelined other veteran Bolsheviks that stood in his way and ruled the country with an iron fist. With the dissolution of USSR, his credibility as the most influential and revolutionary leader of 20th century also suffered a setback. And the capitalist world weaponised this in demonising and vilifying him to the hilt.

However, the vilification drive can hardly overshadow the transformative changes that Lenin's Soviet system brought about and were followed in other nations. Upon assuming power, he issued a series of sweeping decrees, having far-reaching implications and impacts. The public utilities, large-scale enterprises such as the banks, railways, landed estates, textiles, mines and other major industries were nationalised while smaller businesses were allowed to operate privately. The nationalised lands were distributed to the farmers. Similarly, another decree limited work period to eight hours a day. Workers had also acquired right to form committee to monitor the management of industries.

> His ideas are instrumental in the adoption of welfare state and social justice principle in the countries that are hostile to communism.

The government guaranteed free, secular education for all children in Russia. Soviet regime set milestone in boosting women emancipation. Women were given right to property, divorce and abortion. Under Lenin, Russia became the first nation to legalise abortion more than a century ago. This might sound strange for the American women rights activists, who are still hitting the streets to secure abortion right. The Church was separated from the state. As a temporary measure, Lenin banned the opposition media outlets, terming them as counter-revolutionary but this move irked his own Bolshevik comrades. Similarly, he granted rights to the non-Russian ethnic groups to secede from Russian authority and establish their own independent nation-states.

New Economic Policy (NEP), introduced in 1921, marked another significant step in rebuilding the economy crippled by the civil war. Lenin himself called it 'state capitalism' which permitted to run private enterprises, unveil wage system and sell agriculture products on the open market while levying taxes on their incomes. Scores of Bolsheviks were against the NEP, citing that it betrayed the core socialist values. Lenin worked hard to convince his comrades and endorse it into a law. NEP is considered to have influenced Chinese leader Deng Xiaoping to launch his landmark economic reform and opening-up in late 1970s.

Inequality

In his famous work, *'Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism,'* Lenin defines imperialism as the product of monopoly finance capitalism. This argument still holds water in understanding the 21st century's corporate-led globalisation that has increased economic inequality and digital divide by amassing the wealth in the hands of a few businessmen. Because of his hardliner thought, Lenin was isolated by the capitalist West but he found friends and allies in the colonial world. He was the first head of state to champion for the rights of the people in the colonies and semi-colonies, and called for their self-determination and independence, fuelling liberation movements across Asia, Africa and Latin America.

Today historical proletariat class, the product of industrial revolution, is no longer in existence. This class is supposed to carry out the Marxist revolution in the industrial nations. The new social and economic classes have emerged. According to a research, there are at least nine classes in the industrial nations. Carrying out revolution in line with Lenin's revolutionary theory seems unfeasible at the moment due to changed socio-economic realities and conditions but it has forced to drastically reform capitalism, with huge concessions to the working class people. His ideas are instrumental in the adoption of welfare state and social justice principle in the countries that are hostile to communism.

(The author is Deputy Executive editor of this daily.)

Cope With Seasonal Depression

Dr. Shyam P Lohani



Seasonal Affective Disorder (SAD) is a form of depression that distresses millions of people worldwide, and it can have a significant impact on their quality of life. It is a complex mental health condition that typically occurs during the winter months when daylight hours are shorter. SAD can have a profound impact on an individual's overall well-being, making it crucial to raise awareness and understanding about this often misunderstood disorder.

SAD is not simply a case of the "winter blues" but a genuine mental health condition that can significantly impact a person's quality of life. The lack of sunlight during winter months can disrupt the body's internal clock, leading to a range of symptoms including fatigue, low mood, loss of interest in activities, and changes in appetite. These symptoms can be debilitating, affecting one's ability to function at work, maintain relationships, and enjoy life.

Understanding the Causes

It is a form of depression that is related to changes in seasons, with symptoms typically starting in the fall and continuing through the winter months. SAD is estimated to affect around 1-10 per cent of the general population, depending on the geographical location. It is more common in higher latitudes where there are shorter daylight hours during the winter months. SAD is more common in women than in men, with studies suggesting that women are about four times more likely to be affected. The reasons for this gender difference are not fully understood but may be related to hormonal factors. SAD typically starts in early adulthood, with the average age of onset being in the early 20s. However, it can also occur in children, adolescents, and older adults.

SAD is more prevalent in northern latitudes, where there are longer periods of darkness during the winter months. Certain factors increase the risk of developing SAD. These include a family history of depression or SAD, living far from the equator, having a personal or family history of other mood disorders, and having a history of substance abuse. While the exact cause of SAD is still not fully understood, researchers believe that a combination of factors contributes to its development. One of the main causes of SAD is a lack of sunlight. One prominent theory suggests that reduced exposure to sunlight affects the body's internal clock and decreases the production of serotonin, a neurotransmitter that regulates mood.

Additionally, disruptions in the body's circadian rhythm and changes in melatonin levels may also play a role in the onset of SAD. During the winter months, the days are shorter and the sun is lower in the sky, which means that people are exposed to less natural light. The symptoms of SAD can vary from person to person, but they often include feelings of sadness, hopelessness, and anxiety. People with SAD may also experience changes in their appetite and sleep patterns, as well as a lack of energy and motivation.

> By shedding light on SAD, we can foster understanding, empathy, and support for those who experience its debilitating effects.

SAD also causes a lack of energy and increased fatigue, difficulty concentrating and making decisions, increased irritability and agitation, changes in appetite, often with cravings for carbohydrates and weight gain, social withdrawal and decreased interest in activities previously enjoyed, and oversleeping or difficulty sleeping. Physical symptoms such as headaches, body aches, and stomach problems can also be seen in SAD.

Fortunately, there are several treatments available for SAD. One of the most effective is light therapy, which involves exposure to bright artificial light for a set amount of time each day and has shown promising results in alleviating symptoms. This can help regulate the body's internal clock and increase the production of serotonin. Other treatments for SAD include psychotherapy, medication, and lifestyle changes such as exercise and a healthy diet. People with SAD need to seek help from a healthcare professional, as the condition can have a significant impact on their mental health and well-being. In severe cases, medication and psychotherapy may be recommended to provide additional support.

Awareness is important to bring people in need of help to different treatment options. Despite its prevalence, SAD often goes undiagnosed or misdiagnosed due to a lack of awareness and understanding. Many individuals may dismiss their symptoms as a normal part of winter or attribute them to other causes. By raising awareness about SAD, we can encourage individuals to seek help and support, reducing the stigma surrounding mental health and promoting early intervention.

Strategies

For those affected by SAD, various coping strategies can help manage symptoms. Engaging in activities that bring joy and fulfillment, such as hobbies or spending time with loved ones, can provide a much-needed boost. Creating a daily routine, ensuring exposure to natural light, and practicing self-care are also essential in maintaining mental well-being during the winter months.

SAD is a real and significant mental health condition that affects countless individuals each year. By shedding light on SAD, we can foster understanding, empathy, and support for those who experience its debilitating effects. It is crucial to recognise the signs, seek appropriate treatment, and promote self-care strategies to ensure that individuals affected by SAD can lead fulfilling lives, even during the darkest of seasons. It is crucial that if you or someone you know is experiencing symptoms of SAD or any other mental health problem, it is important to seek professional help for proper diagnosis and treatment.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at Health Concern. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 28, 1974

Ropeway Cable To Construct Bridges

Kathmandu, Jan.27: The remote areas and local development department has given 15,730 feet of ropeway cable to construct suspension bridges over the various rivers and streams in Surkhet district, it is learnt, reports RSS

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Emulate Bagmati Govt's Move



This is in reference to the news report titled *"Bagmati govt endorses agro self-reliance scheme"* published in this daily on Jan. 28. According to the report, a cabinet meeting of the Bagmati Province government approved the procedure for implementing the One Ward, One Agriculture Product Programme following the endorsement of the Action Plan.

As part of its policy to make the province self-reliant in agricultural production, the government has accorded top priority to agriculture in its policies, programmes and budget for the current fiscal year. Other provincial governments should follow this example, for it is not only beneficial but also an absolute necessity.

We are a country with diverse geographical landscape spanning from high Himalayas to the plain Terai, and every geography is suitable to cultivate certain kind of agricultural produce. Doing so can not only be a source of food but also a means to earn. And cashing in on this can give a boost to our economy.

Kapil Basyal
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A homeless man, down on his luck, went into a Catholic church that was known for its rather "uppity" social reputation. Spotting the man's dirty clothes, the ushers stopped him outside the church door and asked if he needed help.

The man told them, "I was praying and the Lord told me to come to this church." The ushers suggested that the man go away and pray some more and me might get a different answer. The following Sunday the man returned and the ushers again stopped him at the door.

"Well, did you get a different answer?" they asked him. "Yes, I did," said the man. "I told the Lord that you don't want me here, but the Lord said, 'Keep trying, son. I've been trying to get into that church for years and I haven't made it yet either."

UN court orders Israel to avert genocide in Gaza

AP
The Hague, Netherlands, Jan. 27



PHOTO: AP

Pro-Palestinian activists react near the International Court of Justice, or World Court, in The Hague, Netherlands, Friday, Jan. 26, 2024.

The United Nations' top court on Friday ordered Israel to do all it can to prevent death, destruction and any acts of genocide in Gaza, but the panel stopped short of ordering an end to the military offensive that has laid waste to the Palestinian enclave.

In a ruling that will keep Israel under the legal lens for years to come, the court offered little other comfort to Israeli leaders in a genocide case brought by South Africa that goes to the core of one of the world's most intractable conflicts. The court's half-dozen orders will be difficult to achieve without some sort of cease-fire or pause in the fighting.

"The court is acutely aware of the extent of the human tragedy that is unfolding in the region and is deeply concerned about the continuing loss of life and human suffering," court President Joan E. Donoghue said.

The ruling amounted to an overwhelming rebuke of Israel's wartime conduct and added to mounting international pressure to halt the nearly 4-month-old offensive that has killed more than 26,000 Palestinians, decimated vast swaths of Gaza and driven nearly 85% of its 2.3 million people from their homes.

Allowing the accusations to stand stung the government of Israel, which was founded as a Jewish state after the Nazi slaughter of 6 million Jews during World War II.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said the fact that the court was willing to discuss the genocide charges was a "mark of shame that will not be erased for generations." He vowed to press ahead with the war.

The power of the ruling was magnified by its timing, coming on the eve of International Holocaust Remembrance Day.

Later Friday, U.N. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres stressed that the top court's rulings are legally binding and "trusts" that Israel will comply with its orders, including "to take all measures within its power" to prevent acts that would bring about the destruction of the Palestinian people.

"Those truly needing to stand trial are those that murdered and kidnapped children, women and the elderly," former Israeli Defense Minister Benny Gantz said, referring to Hamas militants who stormed through Israeli communities on Oct. 7 in the attack that set off the war. The assault killed some 1,200 people and resulted in another 250 being kidnapped. The court also called on Hamas to release the hostages who are still in captivity. Hamas urged the international community to make Israel carry out the court's orders.

Many of the measures were approved by an overwhelming majority of the judges. Of the six orders, an Israeli judge voted in favor of two — an order for humanitarian aid and another for the prevention of inflammatory speech.

Israeli Judge Aharon Barak said he supported those orders in the hope that they would "help to decrease tensions and discourage damaging rhetoric" while easing the "consequences of the armed conflict for the most vulnerable."

Such provisional measures issued by the world court are legally binding, but it is not clear if Israel will comply with them.

The court ruled that Israel must do all it can to prevent genocide, including refraining from harming or killing Palestinians. It also ruled that Israel must urgently get basic aid to Gaza and that the country should punish any incitement to genocide, among other measures.

US, Australia and Italy suspend funding for UN Palestine agency

AP
Gaza Strip, Jan. 27



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians arrive in the southern Gaza town of Rafah after fleeing an Israeli ground and air offensive in the nearby city of Khan Younis on Friday, Jan. 26, 2024.

The U.N. agency for Palestinian refugees fired a number of its staffers in Gaza suspected of taking part in the Oct. 7 attack by Hamas and other militants on southern Israel, its director said Friday, prompting the United States — the agency's biggest donor — to temporarily halt its funding.

The agency, known by its acronym UNRWA, has been the main agency providing aid for Gaza's population amid the humanitarian disaster caused by Israel's offensive against Hamas in Gaza triggered by the Oct. 7 attack. UNRWA officials did not comment on the impact that the U.S. halt in funding would have on its operations.

UNRWA chief Philippe Lazzarini said it terminated contracts with "several" employees and ordered an investigation after Israel provided information alleging they played a role in the attack. The U.S. State Department said there were allegations against 12 employees. UNRWA has 13,000 staffers in Gaza, almost all of them Palestinians, ranging from teachers in schools that the agency runs to doctors, medical staff and aid workers.

In a statement, Lazzarini called the allegations "shocking" and said any employee "involved in acts of terror will be held accountable, including through criminal prosecution."

He did not elaborate on what the staffers' alleged role was in the attacks. In the unprecedented surprise attack, Hamas fighters broke through the security fence surrounding Gaza and stormed nearby Israeli communities, killing around 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and kidnapping some 250. Other militants joined the rampage.

"UNRWA reiterates its condemnation in the strongest possible terms of the abhorrent attacks of 7 October" and calls for the immediate and unconditional release of all Israeli hostages, Lazzarini said.

Since the war's start, Israel's assault has killed more than 26,000 Palestinians, most women and children, and wounded more than 64,400 others, Gaza's Health Ministry said Friday. The ministry does not differentiate between combatants and civilians in its death toll. More than 150 UNWRA employees are among those killed — the highest toll the world body has suffered in a conflict — and a number of U.N. shelters have been hit in the bombardment.

More than 1.7 million of Gaza's 2.3 million people have been driven from their homes by the war — with hundreds of thousands of them crowded into schools and other shelters run by UNRWA.

Israel's near-complete seal on Gaza has left almost the entire population reliant on a trickle of international aid able to enter the territory each day. U.N. officials say about a quarter of the population now faces starvation.

The U.S. State Department said it was "extremely troubled" by the allegations against the UNRWA staffers and has temporarily paused additional funding for the agency. The U.S. is the biggest donor to the agency, providing it with $340 million in 2022 and several hundred million in 2023.

Haitians facing gang violence desperate as Kenya court blocks police deployment



PHOTO: AP

Lawyers react as Justice Chacha Mwita delivers judgement on a petition against the deployment of Kenyan forces to Haiti, at Milimani court in the capital Nairobi, Kenya, Friday, Jan. 26, 2024.

AP
Haiti, Jan. 27

Radio stations across Haiti got jammed with calls just hours after a court in Kenya blocked the deployment of a U.N.-backed police force to help fight gangs in the troubled Caribbean country.

Many callers wondered and demanded: What's next?

Few know.

Uncertainty and fear have been spreading since Friday's ruling, with violence reaching new records as gangs tighten their grip on Haiti's capital and beyond.

"Absent a robust external mission that would be deployed very soon, we are facing quite a tragic scenario in Haiti," warned Diego Da Rin with International Crisis Group.

Gangs that control an estimated 80% of Haiti's capital have in recent weeks attacked and seized power of previously peaceful communities, killing and injuring dozens, leading to widespread concerns that they will soon control all of Port-au-Prince.

The number of people reported killed last year in Haiti more than doubled to nearly 4,500, and the number of reported kidnappings surged by more than 80% to nearly 2,500 cases, according to the most recent U.N. statistics.

Meanwhile, Haiti's National Police is losing officers at "an alarming rate," while those still in service continue to be overwhelmed by gangs, according to a U.N. report released this week. More than 1,600 officers left the department last year, and another 48 were reported killed.

In addition, equipment sent by the international community to help bolster an underfunded police department has crumpled beneath heavy fights with gangs.

Yemen Houthi rebels fire a missile at a US warship

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 27



PHOTO: AP

Houthi supporters attend a rally in support of the Palestinians in the Gaza Strip and against the U.S.-led airstrikes on Yemen, in Sanaa, Yemen, Friday, Jan. 26, 2024.

Yemen's Houthi rebels launched a missile Friday at a United States warship patrolling the Gulf of Aden, forcing it to shoot down the projectile, and struck a British vessel as their aggressive attacks on maritime traffic continue.

The attack on the U.S. warship, the destroyer USS Carney, marked a further escalation in the biggest confrontation at sea the U.S. Navy has seen in the Middle East in decades, as Houthi missile fire set another commercial vessel ablaze Friday night.

Early Saturday local time, U.S. forces conducted a strike against a Houthi anti-ship missile that was aimed into the Red Sea and prepared to launch, the U.S. military's Central Command said.

The Houthis' Al-Masirah satellite news channel said the strikes happened near the port city of Hodeida, but offered no assessment of their damage.

The Carney attack represents the first time the Houthis directly targeted a U.S. warship since the rebels began their assaults on shipping in October, a U.S. official said on condition of anonymity because no authorization had been given to discuss the incident.

Later Friday, the British military's United Kingdom Maritime Operations, which oversees Mideast waterways, acknowledged a vessel had been struck by a missile and was on fire in the Gulf of Aden.

Houthi military spokesperson Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree did not acknowledge the Carney attack, but claimed the missile attack on the commercial vessel that set it ablaze. He identified the vessel as the Marshall Islands-flagged tanker Marlin Luanda.

Central Command late Friday confirmed the Marlin Luanda was struck by a single anti-ship ballistic missile fired from Houthi-controlled Yemen. The Carney and other coalition ships responded and were rendering assistance toward the stricken ship. Central Command said no injuries were reported.

The Houthis' now direct attacks on U.S. warships are the most aggressive escalation of its campaign in the Red Sea since the Israel-Hamas war broke out. The U.S. has tried to temper its descriptions of the Houthis' strikes, and said it is difficult to determine what exactly the Houthis are trying to hit in part try to prevent the conflict from becoming a wider regional war.

PRISM

34 Taylor Swift songs in 1 minute for world record

Pakistan: A dedicated Swiftie from Pakistan broke a Guinness World Record by correctly identifying 34 Taylor Swift songs from their lyrics in one minute.

Bilal Ilyas Jhandir, 20, had to listen to the lyrics being read aloud by a man without any accompanying music to identify each song.

The record attempt included Swift's 50 best-selling songs arranged in random order. He managed to identify 34 songs in one minute, breaking the record of 27 set by Dan Simpson in 2019.

"I have been listening to Taylor Swift since my childhood. I am a die-hard fan of her," Jhandir told Guinness World Records. "I have listened to each and every song of hers. I can identify almost any song of hers from the lyrics."

Runaway parrot reunites with owner

England: A singing parrot found wandering loose on the streets of England has been reunited with his owner -- and his canine best friend.

The RSPCA said the cockatiel was found lost on a street in the Kearsley area of Bolton, near Manchester, sparking a search for his owner. The group said the talkative bird, named Ernie, has now being reunited with owner Alison Roberts after she saw video of the bird singing at his foster family's home on Facebook.

Roberts said Ernie was happy to see her again, but not as happy as he was to reunite with the family dog, Lottie.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1624 – Sir Thomas Warner founds the first British colony in the Caribbean, on the island of Saint Kitts.
1909 – United States troops leave Cuba, with the exception of Guantanamo Bay Naval Base, after being there since the Spanish–American War.
1915 – An act of the U.S. Congress creates the United States Coast Guard as a branch of the United States Armed Forces.
1941 – Franco-Thai War: Final air battle of the conflict. A Japanese-mediated armistice goes into effect later in the day.
1945 – World War II: Supplies begin to reach the Republic of China over the newly reopened Burma Road.
2023 – Protests begin after police beat and kill Tyre Nichols.

Australians protest British colonisation on national holiday

AP
Sydney, Jan. 27



PHOTO: AP

People attend an Indigenous Australians protest during Australia Day in Sydney, Friday, Jan. 26, 2024.

Thousands of Australians protested the anniversary of British colonization of their country with large crowds Friday urging for Australia Day to be moved and for a day of mourning on the holiday some call "Invasion Day."

The holiday marks the arrival of 11 British ships carrying convicts at Port Jackson in present-day Sydney on Jan. 26, 1788. For many activists, the day marked the beginning of a sustained period of discrimination and expulsion of Indigenous people from their land without a treaty.

Thousands of people, many of whom waved Indigenous flags, rallied in front of the Victoria state parliament in Melbourne, calling for an official day of mourning to be declared across Australia. Roads and tram lines were shut down for more than four hours.

Large crowds in Sydney chanted for the Australia Day date to be moved. Thousands of protesters also rallied in Brisbane, and the second day of Australia's cricket match against the West Indies was briefly disrupted by demonstrators.

Major sports have stopped calling the holiday Australia Day, and the Australian Football League Players Association, several clubs and hockey teams have called for the date to change.

On Thursday, two monuments symbolizing Australia's colonial past were damaged in Melbourne. A statue of British naval officer James Cook, who in 1770 charted Sydney's coast, was sawn off at the ankles, and a Queen Victoria monument was doused in red paint.

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people represented 3.8% of Australia's population of 26 million, according to a Bureau of Statistics census in 2021. Indigenous people are the nation's most disadvantaged ethnic minority.

Tensions are high after Australian voters in October resoundingly rejected a referendum to create an advocacy committee to offer advice to parliament on policies that affect Indigenous people. The government had proposed the first constitutional change since 1977 as a step forward in Indigenous rights.

Prime Minister Anthony Albanese said Friday that the national day was an opportunity for Australians to "pause and reflect on everything that we have achieved as a nation."

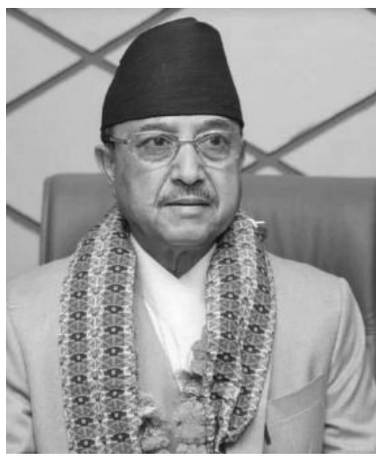


PHOTO: RSS

Kamal Daha or lotus lake situated in Sisne Rural Municipality -5 of Rukum (East) is a tourist destination.

'Govt extends support for reform in journalism'

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 27



DPM Purna Bahadur Khadka

Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka has assured government's support at policy and practical levels for reform in journalism sector.

Releasing a book 'False Front Page' penned by journalist Kalendra Sejuwal, DPM Khadka lauded media that it has played a significant role on public awareness, strengthening of public service and protection and promotion of human rights.

"Journalism should not deviate from right track. It is a collective responsibility," he said, adding that government would support for policy and structural reform in journalism.

The DPM however viewed it is FNJ's major responsibility to carry out institutional development and professional journalism.

Khadka reminded the role of Nepali media that voiced against autocratic Rana regime to party-less panchayat system and for the establishment of present federal democratic republic.

"Journalism is essential to inform people and strengthen democracy. It a voice of voiceless and watchdog as well," DPM Khada mentioned.

Khadka also urged the media persons to maintain facts, balance and credibility in news. Adherence to ethics and code of conduct is equally important, according to him.

DPM Khadka commented on the book penned by Sejuwal that it had analysed well media, politics, and social issues.

The book would be useful in development of journalism, he observed.

Martyr Dharmabhakta remembered

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

A memorial gathering was organised at Siphal, Kalopul in commemoration of martyr Dharmabhakta Mathema this morning.

Mathema had got martyrdom at Siphal, Kalopul in Kathmandu.

The martyr week main organizing committee under Kathmandu metr0politan city organized the memorial event. The martyr week is held from Magh 10 to 16 (January 24 to 30).

Deputy Mayor at Kathmandu metropolis, Sunita Dangol, offered flowers to the Dharmabhakta's statue and viewed they had sacrificed their lives for the sake of people's freedoms.

Ward no 23 of metropolis has set up a park at Ombahal, Kathmandu in honour of martyr Mathema. Even a charity, manav sewa ashram, built by metropolis is named after him, according to Deputy Mayor Dangol.

In the gathering, ward no 7 Chairman, Bimal Hoda, opined that martyrs' dream could be realized with institutional development of good governance and rule of law.

Similarly, Vice Chancellor of Tribhuvan University, Kedar Bhakta Mathema, pointed out the need of making campuses aware on role of martyrs.

Mathema who was born at Ombahal, Kathmandu on Ashwain 9, 1966Bs was arrested by then autocratic Rana regime in Kartik 1997BS for acting against the regime. He was later hanged on a tree at Siphal on Magh 13 the same year.

The autocratic Rana regime had taken the lives of then vibrant fighters for democracy- Shukra Raj Shastri, Dharma Bhakta Mathema, Ganga Lal Shrestha and Dasharath Chand.

Hydropower project machine malfunctions, body washed away



RSS
Salleri (Solukhumbu), Jan. 27

A machine of Likhu II hydropower project suddenly shut down leading to a rise in waterflow in the river today. And a body being cremated was washed away.

The body of 32-year-old Jhapad Bahadur Thapa of Umakunda rural municipality-1 of Ramechhap, that was being cremated on the Likhu river bank, said Ramechhap district police office. The body has gone missing.

According to Chief of Ramechhap Police, DSP Hom Bahadur Parajuli when the water of the dam returned to the river the dead body that was being cremated was washed away and disappeared.

Chief District Officer of Solukhumbu Devi Pandey Khatri said that although the incident site is in Ramechhap, as it is the border of Solukhumbu, a police team has been deployed from Police Station in Kinja.

Biden urges Congress to embrace border bill

US House speaker suggests it may be 'dead on arrival'

AP
Washington, Jan. 27

President Joe Biden on Friday pressed Congress to embrace a bipartisan Senate deal to pair border enforcement measures with Ukraine aid, but House Speaker Mike Johnson suggested the compromise on border and immigration policy could be "dead on arrival" in his chamber.

The Democratic president said in a statement late Friday that the policies proposed would "be the toughest and fairest set of reforms to secure the border we've ever had in our country." He also pledged to use a new emergency authority to "shut down the border" as soon as he could sign it into law.

Biden's embrace of the deal — and Republican resistance — could become an election-year shift on the politics of immigration. Yet the diminishing prospects for its passage in Congress may have far-reaching consequences for U.S. allies around the globe, especially Ukraine.

Senate Republicans had initially insisted that border policy changes be included in Biden's $110 billion emergency request for funding for Ukraine, Israel, immigration enforcement and other national security needs. But the Senate deal faced collapse this week as it came under fire from Republicans, including Donald Trump, the likely presidential nominee, who eviscerated the deal as a political "gift" to Democrats.

Johnson, a Louisiana Republican, on Friday sent a letter to colleagues that aligns him with hardline conservatives determined to sink the compromise. The speaker said the legislation would have been "dead on arrival in the House" if leaked reports about it were true.

A core group of senators negotiating the deal were hoping to release text early next week, but conservatives already say the measures do not go far enough to limit immigration. The proposal would enact tougher standards on migrants seeking asylum as well as deny asylum applications at the border if daily migrant encounters grow to numbers that are unmanageable for authorities.

"Rather than accept accountability, President Biden is now trying to blame Congress for what HE himself intentionally created," Johnson said in the letter.

The speaker's message added to the headwinds facing the Senate deal, closing a week in which Senate Republican Leader Mitch McConnell acknowledged to his colleagues that the legislation faced tough opposition from Trump that could force them to pursue Ukraine aid another way. He later clarified that he was still supportive of pairing border measures with Ukraine aid.



FILE PHOTO: AP

US House Speaker Mike Johnson, R-La., gives a statement to reporters, Jan. 12, 2024, at the Capitol in Washington.

If the deal collapses, it could leave congressional leaders with no clear path to approving tens of billions of dollars for Ukraine. Biden has made it a top priority to bolster Kyiv's defense against Russia, but his administration has run out of money to send ammunition and missiles. Ukraine supporters warn that the impasse in Congress is already being felt on battlefields and leaving Ukrainian soldiers outgunned.

Oklahoma Sen. James Lankford, the lead GOP negotiator in the border talks, has repeatedly urged lawmakers to refrain from passing final judgment on the bill until they receive legislative text and said some of the reports of its contents in conservative media are not accurate depictions of the bill.

The Republican speaker was already deeply skeptical of any bipartisan compromise on border policy. On Friday, he again pointed to a sweeping set of immigration measures that the House passed last year as being the answer to the nation's border challenges. But that bill failed to gain a single Democratic vote then and has virtually no chance of picking up Democratic support now, which would be necessary to clear the Senate.

As they enter an election year, Republicans are seeking to drive home the fact that historic numbers of migrants have come to the U.S. during Biden's presidency. His administration has countered that global unrest is driving the migration and has sought to implement humane policies on border enforcement.

"Securing the border through these negotiations is a win for America," Biden said in the statement. "For everyone who is demanding tougher border control, this is the way to do it."

Still, the speaker leaned into the Republican push on immigration, saying in his letter that the House would hold a vote on impeaching Homeland Security Secretary Alejandro Mayorkas "as soon as possible" after a committee advances articles of impeachment against him next week. Johnson also said he was standing with Texas Gov. Greg Abbott, who has refused to give federal Border Patrol agents access to a riverfront park that is a popular corridor for migrants illegally entering the U.S.

But Johnson is also under potential pressure himself.

If the Senate were to pass an immigration and Ukraine package, he would face a decision about whether to bring the measure to the floor. And while the speaker is skeptical of continued funding for Ukraine, he has also expressed support for halting Russian President Vladimir Putin's advance in Europe.

At the same time, hardline House conservatives have become vocal opponents of any compromise on immigration policy. Rep. Marjorie Taylor Greene, a hard-right Republican of Georgia, has threatened to initiate an effort to oust Johnson if he put the Senate deal on the House floor.

"This bill represents Senate Republican leadership waging war on House Republican leadership," said Sen. Ted Cruz, a Republican of Texas, at a news conference this week.

Still, other Republicans have lamented that conservatives are throwing away an opportunity to gain a victory on an issue they have talked about far more than Democrats.

Opposition from the right has stymied efforts to reform immigration law in Congress for decades. Trump allies have argued that Congress does not need to act because presidents already have enough authority to implement tough border measures.

Susta locals...

It is expected to be inaugurated in April/May 2024. Somehow, Susta locals have been hopeful after the construction of the bridge which they had been raising nationally.

Devkaran Kalwar, Lumbini Provincial Assembly member elected from Susta, said that he had been taking initiatives to address all the issues faced by the locals.

He said, "I am aware of all issues in Susta. I am working to provide citizenships and land ownership certificates to locals by making practical decisions. I have also prioritised development works. I have raised the issue in the Provincial Assembly. For this, we will coordinate with all three levels of government."

'Nepal-India relations...

Leader of Loktantrik Samajwadi Party Rajendra Mahato, civil society leader Dr Sundar Mani Dixit and others expressed their views on deepening Nepal-India relations to benefit the peoples of the both sides.

Also speaking at the event, Deputy Chief of Mission of Indian Embassy in Kathmandu, Prasanna Shrivastava, shared about the unique relations between Nepal and India and added that India and Indians had the opportunity to provide assistance to Nepalis in the time of disasters here in the past.

Chinese assistant significant...

On the occasion, Commercial Counsellor of the Chinese Embassy in Nepal, Xie Yu, said the Nepal-China relations are based on friendship, mutual trust and strategic partnership.

Similarly, Deputy Mayor at Madhyapur Thimi of Bhaktapur, Bijay Krishna Shrestha, informed that Madhyapur Thimi was eager to welcome Chinese tourists.

The city was being developed as a tourist destination, he informed.

Venezuela court disqualifies opposition presidential hopeful

AFP
Caracas, Jan. 27

Venezuela's Supreme Court, loyal to President Nicolas Maduro's government, on Friday disqualified opposition leader Maria Corina Machado -- who handily won a 2023 primary vote -- from seeking election this year.

The court upheld a 15-year ban on Machado, 56, from holding public office, and also confirmed the ineligibility of a possible opposition stand-in -- two-time presidential candidate Henrique Capriles. The United States and others have repeatedly called for the reinstatement of disqualified opposition candidates ahead of elections, for which a date has yet to be set.

Maduro's government and the opposition agreed in talks in Barbados last year to hold a free and fair vote in 2024 with international observers present.

That agreement saw the United States ease sanctions against Venezuela, allowing Chevron to resume limited oil extraction as part of an effort to keep down global prices as the West pressed sanctions on Russia over the war in Ukraine.

It also led to a prisoner swap. But the Supreme Court said Friday Machado would remain disqualified "for being involved... in the corruption plot orchestrated by the usurper Juan Guaido."

Guaido, now in exile, was recognized by dozens of countries as the legitimate winner of elections in 2018 that saw Maduro inaugurated for a second successive term despite widespread fraud claims.

Bartika Eam Rai Back With Stellar Fourth Album

BY MANNU SHAHI



Bartika Eam Rai is a US-based Nepali indie-folk/ art-pop musician and a leading figure of the modern Nepali music industry. Her poetry-like lyrics and luscious vocal timbre has charmed a wide range of followers who dearly adore and brace her artistry. Her discography includes two full-length albums and one EP: a six-track Bimbaakash (2016), an eight-track Taral (2018) and a five-track Si/ Ma- [Na] (2019).

Born on April 26, 1991, in Lalitpur, Bartika got fascinated with music at the tender age of six. Her interests further blossomed with opportunities she received around the age of 11, like performances in family gatherings and school events, and with recording of a few children's songs.

The singer later went on to refine her innate skills with mentors such as Gurudev Kaamat, Shreeti Pradhan, Upendra Lal Singh, Roshan Sharma, and John Shrestha.

However, it was after her departure to the US in 2015 that things started falling in place, as she got a chance to meet and collaborate with musician and producer Diwas Gurung. Already a full-time musician in the New York music scene, Diwas with his musical wisdom, further enhanced the stunningly crafted pieces by Bartika, and together they shaped this exclusive sonic palette that many Nepalis youths turn to as their medium of escaping from the rest of the world.

With accolades like the Hits FM Music Award: Song of the Year and Best Pop Vocal Performance 2018 for the track 'Khai', and Song of the Year 2019 for the track 'Aasha II'. The singer is one of a handful of musicians who can lure in similar, if not larger, reception during her live events as on digital platforms.

And Bartika is back again with her fourth studio album "Aandhii, Ityaadi" comprising eleven tracks releasing each week on Friday starting from January 19 to March 22. Two tracks from the album have already been published: 'Sochchau K Mero Bare?' which is currently trending on 24 as per the Nepal moderated YouTube charts and 'K Hunthyo Hola Hami Sangai Bhayeko Bhaye?' the latest release.

The arrangement and sound engineering duties on the album are handled by Diwas Gurung, while the accompanying lyrics videos are compiled by Katha Haru. Furthermore, four songs in the album feature viola by Kyle Armbrust, two songs feature drums by Anmol Mohra and the album art is fabricated by Sahanshil Dangol.

The songstress organised a series of pre-release shows promoting the album from October 2023 until very recently, in cities across the globe such as London, San Francisco, Charlotte, Dallas, Kathmandu, Lalitpur and Pokhara. These intimate performances exhibited the songs in their most stripped-down raw versions with the singer taking the stage solo having only her melodies, words, acoustic guitar and keyboard on her arsenal.

Both the songs seem a very promising inception for the forthcoming collection. I personally gravitate more towards the first track, 'Sochchau K Mero Bare?' for its melancholic indie-rock euphony. The song deals with feelings of nostalgia, questions regarding one's insecurities or curiosities, hence, connecting with everyone for its vulnerability. Eagerly looking forward to more tasteful releases from the album. Definitely, a recommended listen for enthusiasts looking to unravel exciting Nepali music.

Dev Patel adopts action avatar in 'Monkey Man'

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Jan. 27



Actor Dev Patel is set to present his action avatar in the upcoming action thriller 'Monkey Man' which is set to release in theatres worldwide on April 5.

Hollywood's studio Universal Pictures unveiled the official trailer for the flick, featuring well-choreographed and spectacular fight sequences on Friday night. The movie also marks Patel's debut as a director.

Inspired by the legend of the Hindu god Hanuman, 'Monkey Man' is set in Mumbai, India, and features the 'Lion' star as a man on a quest for vengeance against the corrupt leaders who murdered his mother, and continue to systemically victimise the poor.

'Monkey Man' is produced by Jordan Peele who has earned widespread acclaim for directing horror films that touch upon culture and social issues, especially race relations.

'Dhorpatan' in its third week



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27

Salpa Films has informed that its documentary, Dhorpatan: No Winter Holidays, extended its theatrical release to the third week of the month on Friday.

The 79-minute film, released on January 12, had previously been featured at several prestigious film festivals worldwide in 2023.

Over the past 14 days since its release in Kathmandu, 'Dhorpatan' has cultivated a diverse and growing audience.

Issuing a press release about the film screening on Friday, Salpa Films informed that cinephiles seeking a fresh experience in Nepali cinema have been drawn to the film- initially out of curiosity and subsequently through positive word-of-mouth recommendations.

Buoyed by this encouraging response, the film's producers, distributors, and exhibitors have decided to continue its theatrical screenings.

Director and producer Rajan Kathet said, "Initially, our goal was to find an audience for our unique film or somehow persuade them to give it a chance. Now, people are expressing their eagerness not to miss the opportunity to watch it, and that's why we have opted to prolong our theatrical run."

The film's production, which commenced in 2019, had its world premiere at Sheffield DocFest, UK, in June 2023.

It then made appearances at the DMZ International Documentary Film Festival in South Korea, capturing the hearts of audiences in India at the Dharamshala International Film Festival and Kolkata International Film Festivals.

In December 2023, the documentary received the Nativa prize at the Alter Nativa Film Awards in Kazakhstan, acknowledging its cultural significance.

Additionally, it was honoured as the Best Documentary at the Nepal Human Rights International Film Festival 2023.

Wrestling bigwig Vince McMahon resigns after sex abuse suit

AP
Stamford, Jan. 27



Wrestling icon Vince McMahon resigned Friday from WWE's parent company the day after a former employee filed a federal lawsuit accusing him and another former executive of serious sexual misconduct, including offering her to a star wrestler for sex.

McMahon stepped down from his position as executive chairman of the board of directors at WWE's parent company, TKO Group Holdings, according to a statement released late Friday. He continued to deny wrongdoing following the lawsuit filed by Janel Grant, who worked in the company's legal and talent departments.

The suit includes allegations that McMahon, now 78, forced Grant into a sexual relationship in order for her to get and keep a job and passed around pornographic pictures and videos of her to other men, including other WWE employees.

The AP typically does not name accusers in sexual assault cases, but Grant's representatives said she wished to go public. Her lawyer declined to comment. McMahon's statement said that he was leaving the board "out of respect" for WWE and TKO Group.

"I stand by my prior statement that Ms. Grant's lawsuit is replete with lies, obscene made-up instances that never occurred, and is a vindictive distortion of the truth," he said in the statement. "I intend to vigorously defend myself against these baseless accusations, and look forward to clearing my name."

McMahon stepped down as WWE's CEO in 2022 amid an investigation into allegations that match those in the lawsuit, which was filed Thursday in US District Court in Connecticut, where WWE is based.

McMahon was the leader and most recognisable face at WWE for decades. When he purchased what was then the World Wrestling Federation from his father in 1982, wrestling matches took place at small venues and appeared on local cable channels. WWE matches are now held in professional sports stadiums, and the organisation has a sizable overseas following.

WWE merged last April with the company that runs Ultimate Fighting Championship to create the US$ 21.4 billion sports entertainment company TKO Group Holdings, and McMahon served as that group's executive chairman of the board until Friday.

TKO Group's representative referred media inquiries about McMahon's resignation to his statement. Deadline first reported that he was stepping down.

"Mr. McMahon does not control TKO nor does he oversee the day-to-day operations of WWE," TKO Group said earlier this week. "While this matter pre-dates our TKO executive team's tenure at the company, we take Ms. Grant's horrific allegations very seriously and are addressing this matter internally."

Grant also names as defendants in the lawsuit the WWE and John Laurinaitis, an ex-pro wrestler and the company's former head of talent relations and general manager. WWE and Laurinaitis did not return requests for comment Friday.

According to the lawsuit, McMahon lived in the same building as Grant and in 2019 offered to get her a job at WWE after her parents died.

She alleges that he eventually made it clear that one of the requirements of the job was a physical relationship with him and later with Laurinaitis and others. Over the next few years, McMahon lavished her with gifts including a luxury car, the suit says.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: When it comes to life, you may discover that you're capable of supporting someone else or even bringing in additional revenue streams for yourself and another person.

TAURUS: Your energy encourages the people around you. Your dreams and goals might speak to something deep inside of others around you. They could be hoping that you will show them how to follow in your footsteps.

GEMINI: Right now, secrets might make friends! You're potentially working on a secret project with someone close, whether it's for your careers or personal lives.

CANCER: Someone in your life may be about to ask you for a favour, one that you know you're capable of. You don't have to drop everything that you're doing to help them, but you can be their hero.

LEO: What promises have you made to yourself? Take this moment to think back and ponder on them. Focus on routines that would improve your life and provide you with energy.

VIRGO: You may have been working hard in pursuit of your dreams, but you're now able to step aside and rest with someone who means a lot to you. While it can be difficult to pull yourself away from work.

LIBRA: Relatives are potentially asking for your support. Your ability to think outside the box could solve an issue that has long been troubling them. They may not understand your method though, so be patient with them.

SCORPIO: Make an effort to push through introversion and open up to aid from others. It's impossible to be entirely self-reliant, as no one can have every skill in the whole world.

SAGITTARIUS: You're able to gain a support system. You might be attempting to build supportive structures, potentially through a spiritual organisation, a group of friends.

CAPRICORN: You're seeking stimulation. You might be feeling bored or stagnant. So, consider returning to hobbies that excited you or calling someone who thrills you. Say what's on your heart and do what makes you feel alive.

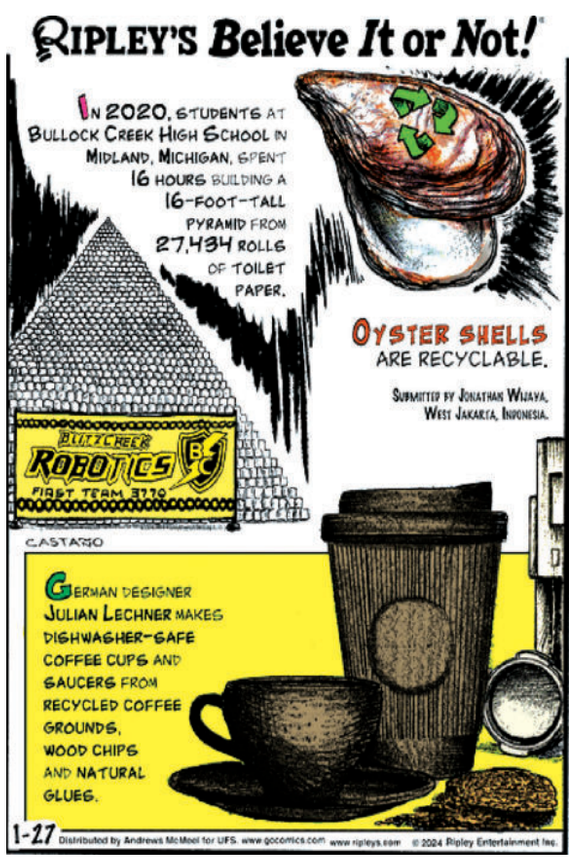
AQUARIUS: Progress might be coming to you in the form of a mentor. There could be someone that you admire and, even if you don't know them personally, you may want to look up interviews with them.

PISCES: Working with other people increases your chances of success. Don't be afraid of looking silly or being a beginner. Collaborate and see where it takes you.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Surya Tamang hits 30-wicket milestone in group stage with a six-for against Lumbini

APF keeps playoffs' hope alive defeating Gandaki by 88 runs.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 27



PHOTO: CAN
Surya Tamang of Bagmati celebrates a wicket against Lumbini Province at TU International Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Saturday.

In one of the two matches of Day 15, Bagmati Province won its final group-stage match of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament defeating Lumbini Province by six wickets at TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday.

Surya Tamang was the hero for Bagmati once again as he claimed his second six-wicket haul in the tournament. With the sixth wicket against Lumbini, Tamang ended the group stage with a total of 30 wickets under his belt.

Earlier, Tamang took a six-for against Madhes in the team's third group match and a five-for against Tribhuwan Army later. Tamang is followed by Sudur Pashchim's Sher Malla (21 wickets in six matches) and Madhes' Ranjit Kumar (19 wickets in eight matches).

Electing to field first, Bagmati bundled out Lumbini in the 33rd over at 106 runs. Alongside six wickets by Tamang, Bipin Acharya bagged two and Krijan Gurung and Pratis GC took one each.

Nirmal Gurung stayed not out for Lumbini at 27 runs in 32 deliveries. Lumbini's captain Sushant Thapa was the team's highest scorer with 28 off 55. Only two others – Birat Bhandari (13 off 29) and Prajjwol Thapa (14 off 25) – scored in double figures for Lumbini.

On the other hand, Bagmati only lost four wickets to chase the target in 17.2 overs. Opener Ashutosh Ghiraiya, who has been dangerous in many matches, could not add runs to his heart's content today as he departed in the fourth over at 14 runs off 11 deliveries.

However, Ishan Pandey, who failed to perform in the previous matches, registered his first half-century in the edition before getting caught in the 17th over. Captain Rit Gautam also added 24 off 33. Rabin Joshi (7 off 4) stayed not out with Bipin Acharya (0 off 2) to win the match for Bagmati.

Tamang and Ghiraiya, who currently has the most runs in the tournament, can continue to extend their achievements if Bagmati qualifies as one of the top four teams. Bagmati is currently in the second position with 12 points (six wins in nine matches) after completing its group-stage matches. With the other nine teams having a couple of games in hand, Bagmati's chance for playoffs is still hanging by a thread.

Meanwhile, Armed Police Force (APF) Club defeated Gandaki Province by 88 runs in the second match of the day at Mulpani International Cricket Ground. Electing to field first, Gandaki bundled out APF in the 48th over at 207 runs. Opener Lokesh Bam got out after reaching the 50-run mark while Bhuvan Karki fell five runs short of his half-century for APF. Two other batsmen to score in double figures for APF were Puran BK (30 off 46) and Pradeep Airee (39 off 45).

Aasif Sheikh and captain Rohit Paudel only added 3 and 4 runs respectively.

Kamal Pariyar bagged three wickets while Bipin Khatri, Amrit Gurung and Sandeep Parajuli claimed two each.

Chasing the target of 208 with confidence, Amar Routela came as a nightmare for Gandaki as he took the wickets of the two openers – Ishwar Chhetri (28 off 30) and Sameer Kandel (33 off 64). Krish Ayer (1 off 6) and Amrit Gurung (0 off 4) were the other two victims of Routela.

Mousom Dhakal also bagged three wickets – Muskan Thapa (7 off 19), Chandra Paudel (1 off 12) and Sandeep Parajuli (golden duck) – alongside two wickets by Bhuvan Karki and one by Ramesh Kurmi to send 10 batsmen of Gandaki back to the pavilion at 119 runs in 33.4 overs. APF, which is in the sixth position with 8 points, will have to win its remaining two matches to keep its hope for the playoffs alive.

Ollie Pope's century powers England to 126-run lead over India in first test

AP
Hyderabad, Jan. 27

Ollie Pope scored a hundred to help England storm back into the first test against India on Day 3 at the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium.

Pope finished the day at 148 not out and put on three vital partnerships as England reached 316-6 in 77 overs in the second innings, taking a 126-run l ead at stumps.

This was after India was bowled out for 436 in its reply to England's 246 in the first innings. The hosts had taken a 190-run lead but it was wiped off nearly by the tea break.

Post-lunch, England's game plan of playing reverse sweep against spin worked wonders. Pope and Ben Duckett extended their second-wicket partnership to 68 runs.

Their stand came off only 57 balls and unnerved the Indian camp, which brought on Jasprit Bumrah to counter with pace.

Bumrah got the ball reversing and bowled Duckett for 47 runs. He faced 52 balls, hitting seven fours in all.

The Indian speedster got a second wicket without delay, trapping Joe Root for just two runs as England was down to 117-3 in 21 overs.

There was a mini-partnership between Pope and Jonny Bairstow — worth 23 runs — before the latter was bowled shouldering arms to Ravindra Jadeja.

Despite that success, Jadeja went for runs through the day and finished with 1-101 in 26 overs, bowling only one maiden.

Ravichandran Ashwin also picked a wicket, bowling Ben Stokes (6) with a sharp off-spinner. England was suddenly five-down and went to tea at 172-5.

On resumption, Pope and Ben Foakes put on the most vital partnership of the innings for England. They put on 112 runs off 183 balls, with both batters looking to score at every opportunity, putting pressure back on the Indian spinners.

Pope had reached 50 off 54 balls in the previous session and marched on to his first second innings century off 154 balls. The second 50 runs were more sedate given that England lost a few more wickets, but the scoring rate picked up later on in the last session.



PHOTO: MAHESH KUMAR A. VIA AP
England's Ollie Pope celebrates his hundred runs against India in Hyderabad, India, Saturday.

Pope was dropped on 110 off Jadeja, with Axar Patel putting down a regulation chance off yet another reverse sweep.

Patel made amends by bowling Foakes for 34 runs to provide a vital breakthrough for India. Pope, though, denied the hosts further, adding another 41 off 62 balls for an unbroken seventh wicket stand with Rehan Ahmed (16 not out).

It was only the fourth time — after Ken Barrington (1961), Mike Gatting (1984) and Jonathan Trott (2012) — an English batter scored a hundred in India.

Earlier in the morning session, Joe Root took 4-79 as India crashed from overnight 421-7 to lose three wickets for 15 runs across 21 deliveries.

Jadeja was out for 87, missing out on his fourth test hundred, out lbw to Root who was denied a hat trick.

India's lead was cut down to 101 runs as the English top order set a quick pace in its second innings to reach 89-1 off 15 overs at lunch.

SNIPPETS

NRT wins 1st NRNA Ilam Gold Cup

Kathmandu (TRN): The New Road Team (NRT) won the 1st edition of the NRNA Ilam Gold Cup in Ilam defeating Biratmod United FC in penalties on Saturday. Playing in front of thousands of football fans from the hilly district of Ilam, both teams failed to score a single goal in the 90 minutes of the game. Hishub Thapaliya, who sent Jawalakhel to the quarter-finals in the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup, could not do the same for Birtamod despite travelling to and back from Pokhara. The winner of the tournament, NRT, received a cash prize of Rs. 500,000 alongside a trophy while Birtamod United FC received Rs. 300,000.

Three Star defeats Bhutan's Paro FC

Kathmandu (TRN): Three Star Football Club defeated Bhutan's Paro FC 2-0 in the first quarter-finals of the ongoing 23rd edition of the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup on Saturday. Three Star fixed its date against Paro after defeating the tournament host Sahara Club on January 23. Ashish Chapagain scored both goals for Three Star to win against the foreign club. The two goals came in three minutes – 26th and 29th – after which Three Star dominated the overall match. Moreover, Ashish had a chance to register a hat-trick, but he could not capitalise on it. Sankata Club and Tribhuwan Army are vying in the second quarter-finals of the tournament on Sunday.

Pokhara's riders organising Moto-Enduro Championship

Kaski (TRN): Pokhara Riders Club made public its plan to organise the 'Pokhara Moto-Enduro Cross Championship 2024' at a press conference in Pokhara on Saturday. According to the club, the championship will be organised on April 5 and 6 in Pame and Bamdi areas targeting World Sports Day (April 6). "Pokhara Riders Club is a new club. However, we are committed to organise a high-level racing championship along a tuff terrain. It is a first-of-its-kind tournament in Nepal for dirt bikes and all-terrain vehicles (ATV)," said Jagat Dhauli, coordinator of the programme. The championship is said to be a national-level tournament and the application process has already begun. "Every participant needs to pay a registration fee of Rs. 17,000," said Dhauli. The championship will have two categories – open and female. The winner of each category will receive a cash prize of Rs. 150,000, the second-positioned rider will get Rs. 100,000 and the third will receive Rs. 50,000. The club's chairman, Sonik Chhetri, informed that the club plans to attract youths toward such sports and create a platform to earn a livelihood from it.

Aryna Sabalenka beats Zheng Qinwen to clinch consecutive Australian Open titles

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 27

Winning her first Grand Slam title in Australia a year ago gave Aryna Sabalenka the confidence she could do it again. Losing the U.S. Open final last September gave her the extra motivation.

No. 2-ranked Sabalenka clinched back-to-back Australian Open titles with a 6-3, 6-2 win over Zheng Qinwen on Saturday in a one-sided women's final that contrasted sharply with her comeback three-set victory here over Elena Rybakina last year.

Sabalenka set the tone by breaking Zheng's serve early in each set in a 76-minute victory over 21-year-old Zheng, who was making her debut in a Grand Slam final.

The journey and the destination were equally important for Sabalenka.

In the semifinals, she avenged her U.S. Open final loss to No. 4-ranked Coco Gauff with a straight-set win over the reigning major champion. That followed straight-sets wins over 2021 French Open winner Barbora Krejcikova in the quarterfinals and Amanda Anisimova in the fourth round. She didn't drop a set all tournament, and only one — a tiebreaker against Gauff — went past 10 games.



PHOTO: AUSTRALIAN OPEN'S FACEBOOK
Aryna Sabalenka with the trophy.

In the end, she needed five championship points before finishing off with a forehand crosscourt winner. It was the kind of shot that had kept Zheng on the back foot almost from the start.

Sabalenka is the first woman since Victoria Azarenka in 2012 and '13 to win back-to-back Australian Open titles, and the fifth since 2000 to win the championship here without dropping a set — a group that includes Serena Williams.

It was the second time in as many majors their paths had met in the second week. Sabalenka beat Zheng in the U.S. Open quarterfinals last year on her way to the final.

Zheng's push to the final was two rounds better than her previous best run to the quarterfinals in New York last September.

She was the first player in four decades to advance through six rounds without playing anyone ranked in the top 50 — and was only the third in the Open era to reach a major final without facing a seeded player.

The step up against No. 2-ranked Sabalenka proved huge.

Australia needs 156 runs to beat West Indies

AP
Brisbane, Jan. 27

West Indies made early inroads through its pace and made Australia work hard for the first time in its dominant test summer during the day-night test match at the Gabba on Saturday.

Australia lost its recently named test player of the year Usman Khawaja (10) and Marnus Labuschagne (5) to end Day 3 at 60-2, still needing 156 runs to make a clean sweep of its test summer that saw them rout Pakistan 3-0 and beat the West Indies by 10 wickets inside three days in the first test at Adelaide.



PHOTO: AAP IMAGE VIA AP
Australia's Cameron Green, right, celebrates taking a wicket in Brisbane, Saturday.

Josh Hazlewood picked up 3-23 with his impeccable bowling and Nathan Lyon grabbed 3-42 with Starc and Cameroon Green picking up one wicket apiece.

Shamar Joseph walked off in a lot of pain and might not be able to bowl in the remainder of the test match.

Justin Greaves then squared up Labuschagne with a brilliant back-of-the-length delivery as Kevin Sinclair snapped a superb diving catch in the second slip.

Steven Smith, who is yet to make an impression in his new role as an opener after the retirement of David Warner, was unbeaten on 33 with Cameroon Green negotiating the last half an hour, not out on 9.

The tourists were progressing well at 148-4, ahead by 170 runs, when first innings' half-century-maker Kavem Hodge was sharply run out by Travis Head. Hodge had frustrated Australia for 74 balls in scoring a patient 29 before he took a few steps outside his crease. Head showed brilliant reflexes at forward short leg and flicked the ball back onto the stumps with Hodge failing to ground his bat back in time.

Kirk McKenzie (41) and Alick Athanaze (35) both looked to have challenged Australian bowlers but both fell to Lyon on either side of the first two sessions as the offspinner found an appreciable turn and bounced off the third day's wicket.

Lyon struck almost immediately when introduced into the attack with the veteran spinner teasing out McKenzie leg before wicket. Green should have had another wicket in the penultimate over before the dinner break but Smith spilt the one-handed chance at slip to give Athanaze a reprieve.

Cummins' decision to give his fast bowlers a chance to bowl with the pink ball under lights for half an hour paid off as Hazlewood found a faint edge from Tagenarine Chanderpaul's bat in the last over of the day with the West Indies at 13-1 at stumps for an overall lead of 35 runs.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:53 am, Sunset at 5:41 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly to generally cloudy throughout the country.. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 15 - 17°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.1	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	22.2	2.4	0.0
Dhangadi	10.7	5.5	0.0
Birendranagar	21.8	2.3	0.0
Nepalgunj	11.3	5.8	0.0
Jumla	13.6	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	18.6	5.0	0.0
Pokhara	18.6	6.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	11.6	4.8	0.0
Simara	13.3	4.8	0.0
Kathmandu	16.5	2.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	13.2	4.2	0.0
Taplejung	13.8	3.5	0.5
Dhankuta	19.5	5.8	0.0
Biratnagar	15.7	7.3	0.0
Jomsom	7.1	-5.5	0.0*
Dharan	20.0	8.3	0.0*
Lumle	14.0	3.0	0.0*
Janakpur	16.4	8.0	0.0*
Jiri	12.3	-2.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 28, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.69	Rs. 133.29
Euro	1	Rs. 144.29	Rs. 144.94
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.09	Rs. 169.85
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.86	Rs. 154.56
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.58	Rs. 87.98
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.70	Rs. 99.15
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.07	Rs. 99.51
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.99	Rs. 9.03
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.50	Rs. 18.59
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.57
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.73	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.94	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.75	Rs. 12.81
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.35	Rs. 19.44
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.98	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.39	Rs. 433.34
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.99	Rs. 353.58

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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